

Client Delivery Realities for Fractional CMOs

What 27 practitioners revealed about how client work is organised, delivered, and perceived — and where the structural gaps are.

63%

manage 1–2 active clients

59%

operate with contractors

74%

use Google Drive as primary storage

27

PRACTITIONERS

4

COUNTRIES

Canada · United States · United Kingdom · Australia

May – Jun 2026

FIELDWORK

Survey conducted via Tally.so

firmä

ORGANIZE · PROTECT · DELIVER

How Work Gets Delivered Today

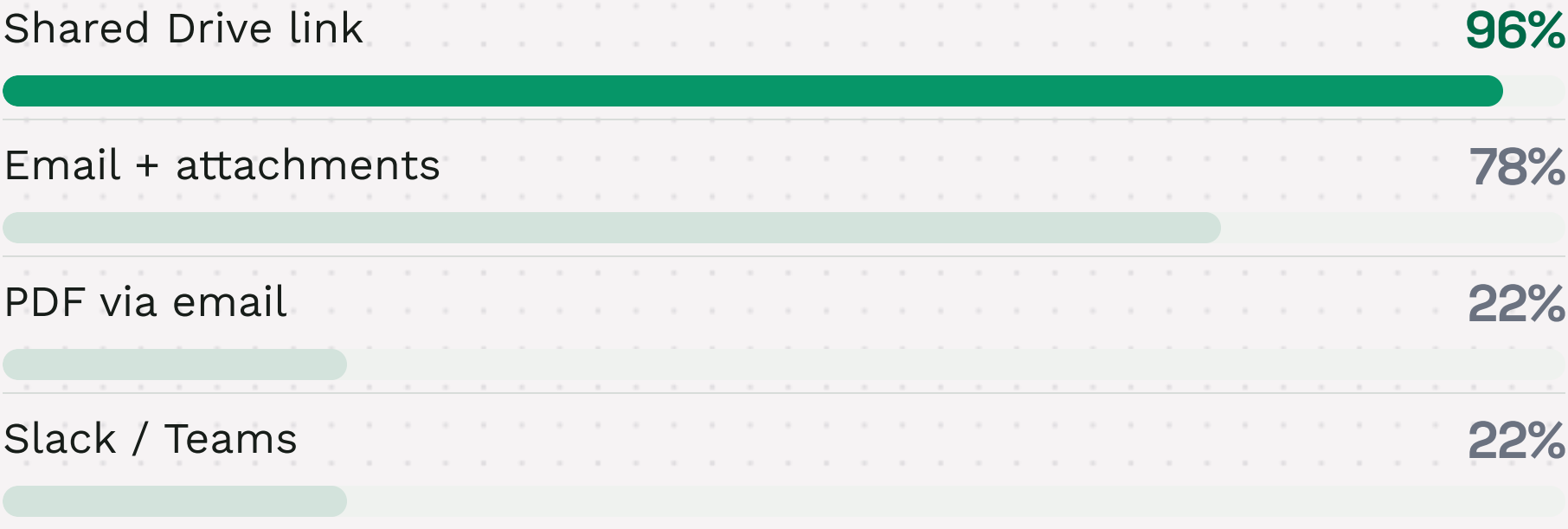
96%

use shared drive links to deliver client work

0%

use a dedicated client portal

■ HOW WORK IS DELIVERED – % OF RESPONDENTS



■ OPERATIONAL FRICTION

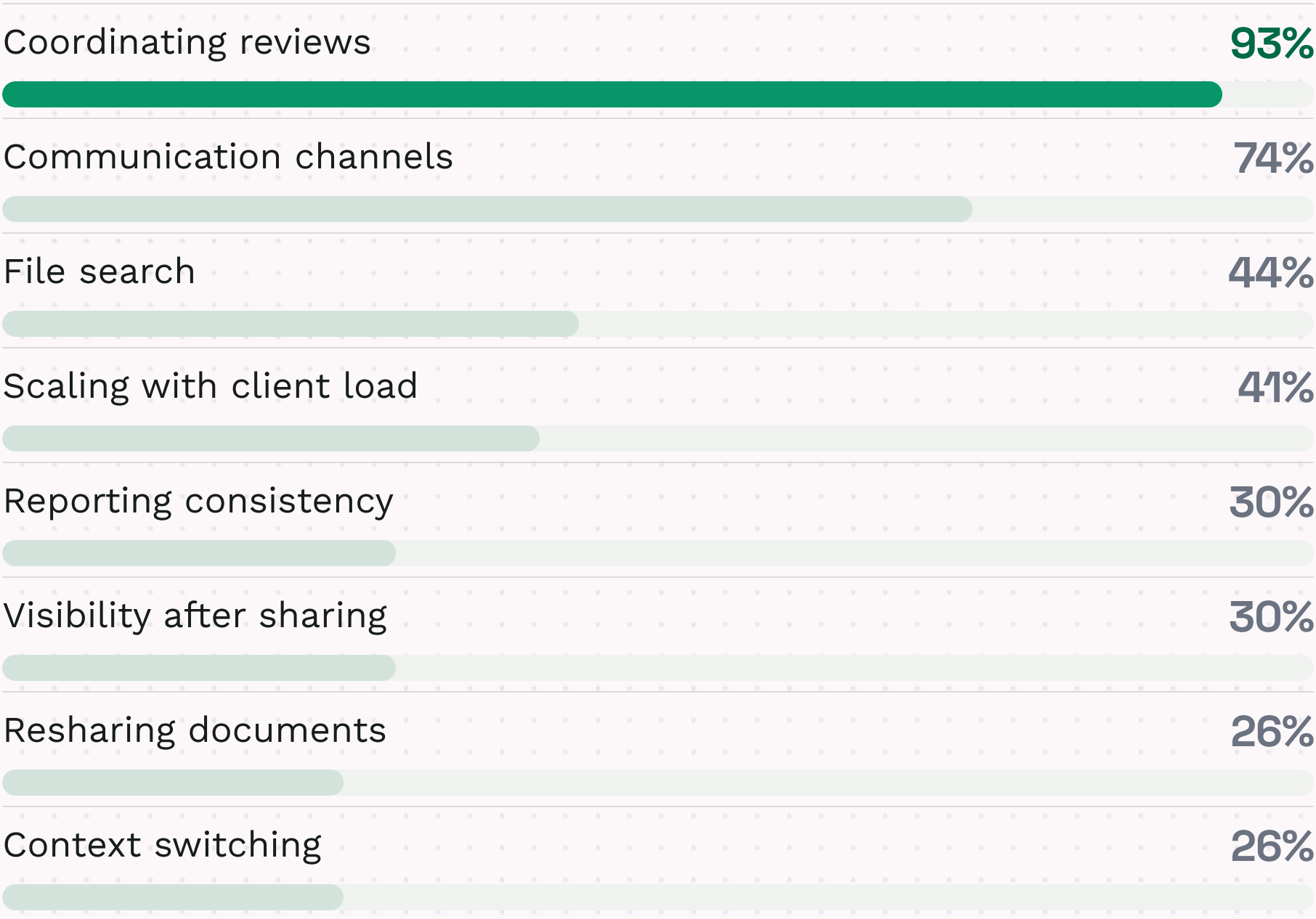
The #1 Friction Point: Coordinating Reviews

93%

say coordinating reviews & approvals creates the most friction

Communication and approval coordination dominate the friction profile — well ahead of file search or scaling concerns.

■ CITED AS A TOP FRICTION POINT



The Hidden Time Tax

Every practitioner surveyed loses measurable time every week to searching for files, resharing links, clarifying versions, and recreating client context — before any billable work begins.

37%

lose 1–3 hours per week to delivery admin overhead

63%

lose up to 1 hour per week — still 26–52 hrs/year

↗ At a conservative 1 hr/week average, that's **over 50 hours per year per practitioner** spent on delivery overhead — not client work.

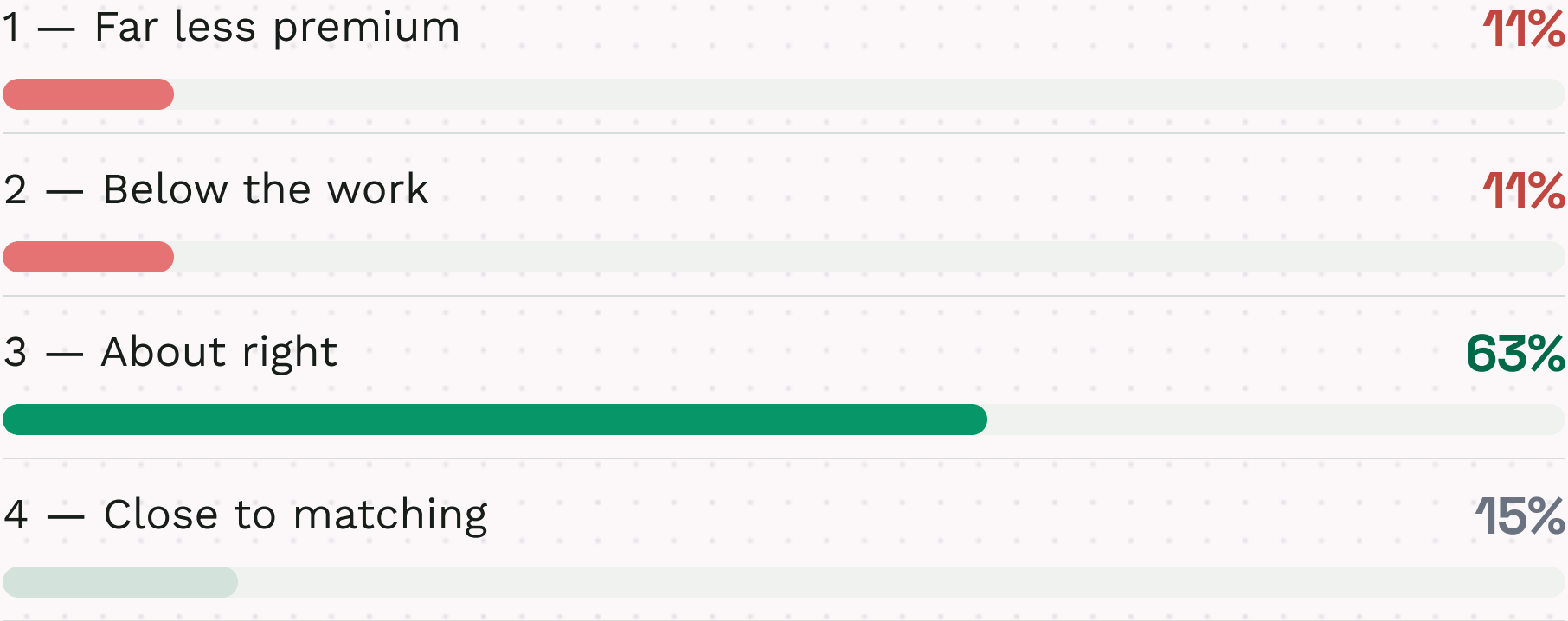
The Perception Gap

22%

feel their delivery experience
is below the quality of their
work

Only **15%** feel their delivery experience
is close to or matches the quality of
their actual work. For the majority, the
gap is real — clients see process, not
just output.

■ HOW PREMIUM DOES DELIVERY FEEL?



When Delivery Costs Deals

22%

have definitely or possibly lost a renewal, referral, or upsell because of **how** their work was delivered — not the quality of the work itself

■ HAS DELIVERY EVER COST YOU A DEAL?



- Don't think delivery affected outcomes
- Maybe — it's possible

- No — never lost a deal for this reason
- Yes — definitely lost a deal

The Access Problem After Engagement Ends

Once a Google Drive folder or file link is shared, most practitioners never remove that access — even after the engagement ends.

63%

don't actively revoke access after engagements end

26%

aren't sure whether former clients still have access

11%

manually remove access on a case-by-case basis

33%

have thought about or confirmed IP exposure after an engagement

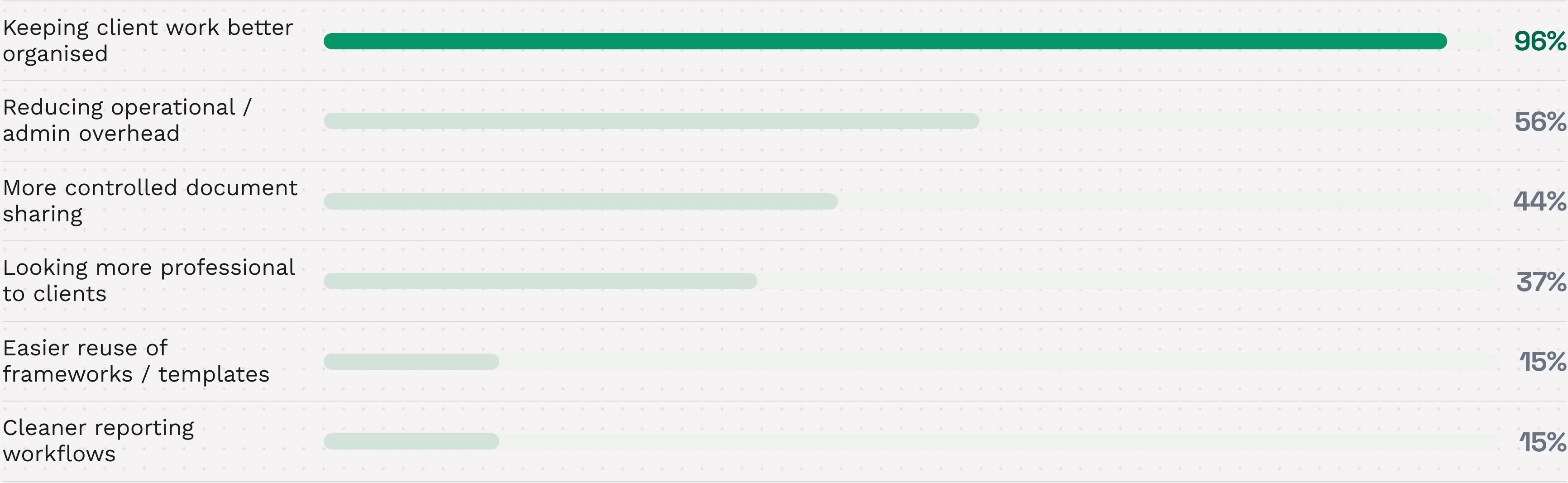
67%

have never had a concern — but 89% also never actively revoke access

■ WHAT WOULD HELP MOST

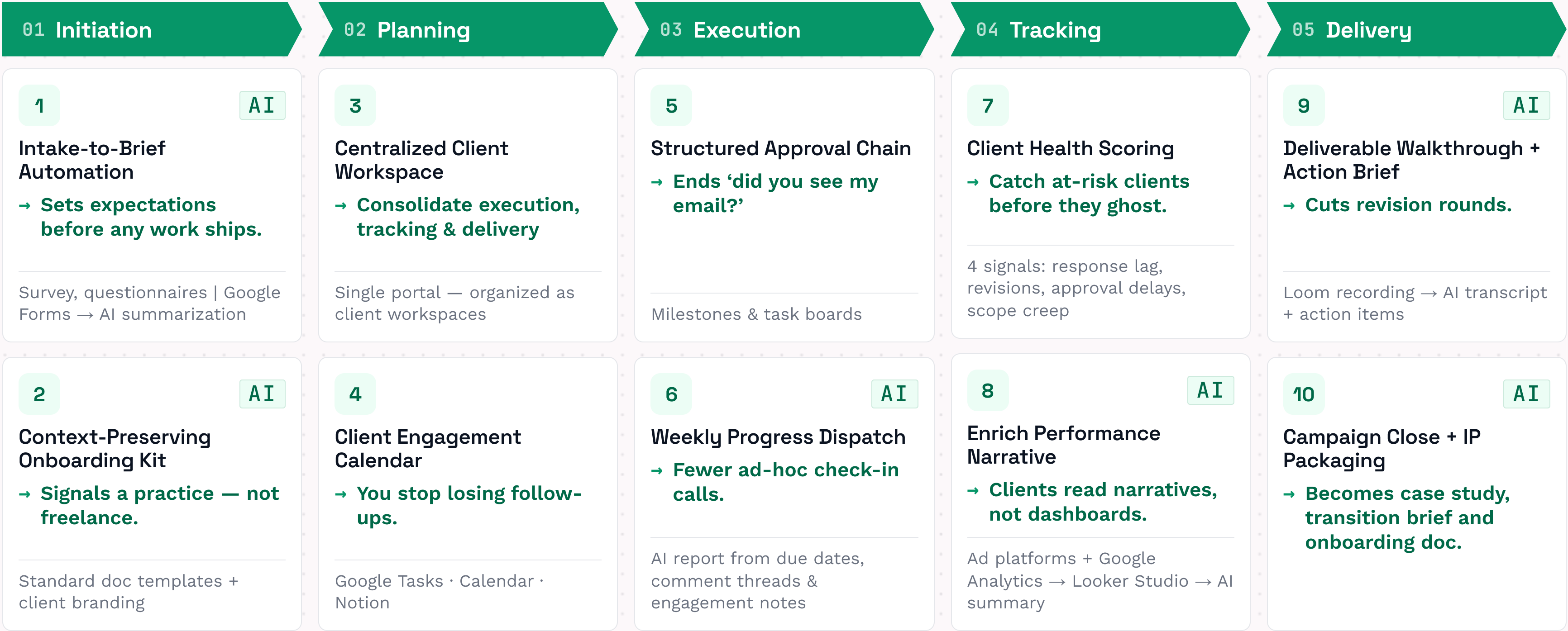
What Practitioners Want Changed

When asked which improvements would have the biggest impact on their client delivery workflow:



The Operational Playbook

Ten systems across the full engagement lifecycle — two per stage, from first contact to close.



■ THE BUSINESS CASE

A Portal Isn't a Tool. It's Infrastructure.

Delivery quality is now a revenue lever. Retention, referrals, and capacity to scale all move with how structured your delivery is.

70%

had never heard of a dedicated client portal tool before this survey. The category is largely undiscovered — and the market gap is significant.

22%

have lost a client because of delivery quality.

RETENTION

Clients leave quietly — and rarely explain why.

Structured delivery turns every touchpoint into a trust signal. Organized engagement → longer relationships, fewer surprise non-renewals.

REFERRALS

You're referred for process, not just results.

The first thing a client tells a peer is how easy you were to work with. A portal-driven engagement is a talking point. Email + Dropbox is forgettable.

IP PROTECTION

Independent research shows 63% practitioners still have open links to ex-clients right now.

Every unrevoked link is uncontrolled access to your methodology. A portal with scoped, time-bound access removes this liability at offboarding.

SCALABILITY

Shared drives collapse at 5+ concurrent clients.

A portal holds the same structure at 2 clients or 20. The bottleneck shifts from coordination overhead to actual strategic capacity.

■ THE SOLUTION

The engagement is the unit of client work — not the file.

■ THE DATA MODEL

01 Your Firm



02 Client



03 Engagement



04 Document



Branded client portal

Your logo, your brand — a premium showcase clients trust on sight.



Engagement templates

Standardize and reuse your delivery across every client and project.



Persona access control

Four roles for internal and external collaborators — the right eyes only.



One-click Wrap

Close an engagement and instantly revoke all client access.



Branded

Your logo and brand system — a premium client showcase.



Non-custodial

Files never leave your Google Drive. Leave anytime, keep everything.



Structured

Engagement-level organization, consistent across every client.

■ BUILT FOR THIS

firmä was built for exactly this.

Every gap in this research is addressed today — or already on the way.

CURRENT REALITY

- Coordinating reviews & approvals — the #1 friction point

93%
- Raw Drive links — no delivery layer

96%
- Access never revoked when an engagement ends

63%
- Fractional executives are largely unaware of dedicated client portals

70%
- 50+ hrs/year lost to admin and version confusion

100%

Recover this alone and firmä pays for itself.

LIVE ON FIRMÄ

- Engagement Workspaces**

Firm → Client → Engagement → Document
- Branded Client Portal**

Your brand on a structured workspace
- Persona Access Control**

Four simple roles that fit any type of operation; expose only what's needed
- Inherited Native Google Docs Capabilities**

Edit Docs, Sheets & Slides live — nothing to re-learn
- Document Intake**

File upload is also available for clients — subject to your approval
- Document Comment Threads**

Async collaboration via in-app comment threads
- Audit Log**

Every action logged, append-only. Use it as audit or signaling operating patterns
- Approve / Finalize**

Mark deliveries as finalized/approved and lock them — no email sign-offs
- Shares Dashboard**

Track every share in one place
- Action Centre**

Approvals, due dates & shares in one view
- Semantic Search**

Search by intent. Not just by exact name.
- Reminders, Bookmarks & Recent History**

Pick up exactly where you left off
- Non-custodial by design**

Files never leave your Google Drive — leave anytime
- One-click Wrap**

Close the engagement and instantly revoke access to engagements in firmä, including revocation of the Google Drive assets.

ROADMAPPED

- Onboarding Kit**

Configure re-usable Engagement templates (document-set)

ROADMAPPED
- Intake-to-Brief Automation**

Intake form → AI brief into the Dossier

FUTURE
- Weekly Progress Dispatch**

Scheduled AI digest from existing signals

FUTURE
- Client Health Scoring**

Add Four risk signals' based scoring to existing Overview page

ROADMAPPED
- Campaign Close + IP Packaging**

We already have 1-click engagement wrap. Enhance to generate closing package at wrap

ROADMAPPED
- MS OneDrive / SharePoint Integration**

Connect Microsoft OneDrive & SharePoint as a storage backend

ROADMAPPED

Thank You

for being part of this research.

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■ KEY TAKEAWAYS

- 01 96%** of practitioners still deliver work through drive links and email — no dedicated delivery layer exists.
- 02 93%** struggle to coordinate reviews & approvals; communication fragmentation is the norm, not the exception.
- 03 22%** have lost deals because of how work was delivered — not the quality of the work.
- 04 63%** of practitioners never revoke document access after engagements end, creating real IP risk.
- 05 70%** had never heard of a dedicated client portal tool — the category is largely undiscovered.